Mise-en-Scène: Composition

Composition

Design and lighting function as elements of mise-en-scène. But what really makes mise-en-scène work is how those visual elements are arranged within each shot. A shot's **composition** is the organization, distribution, balance, and general relationship of objects and figures, as well as of light, shade, line, color, and movement within the frame.

Composition is important for a number of reasons. A consistent approach to composition over the course of the movie helps ensure that the movie's overall style will have aesthetic unity. How elements are arranged helps guide the viewer's eye through the frame and makes us aware of what elements are most significant at any given moment. Composition can minimize or enhance the appearance of depth in a shot. And, perhaps most important, the way elements are organized on-screen can help viewers understand a character's state of mind and interpret different characters' physical, emotional, and psychological relationships to one another.

Two shots from William Wyler's *The Best Years of Our Lives* (1946) illustrate how triangular compositions are used to represent the intertwined lives of three veterans. The men meet when they all hitch a ride home from the war in the same decommissioned bomber.

***The Best Years of Our Lives* (William Wyler, 1946)**

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Their close physical grouping on that trip reflects the tight emotional bond they have only recently established. Much later, a similar tripoint pattern conveys a much less intimate relationship. Time has changed their lives, and the same old patterns have different meanings within the larger context.

***The Best Years of Our Lives* (William Wyler, 1946)**

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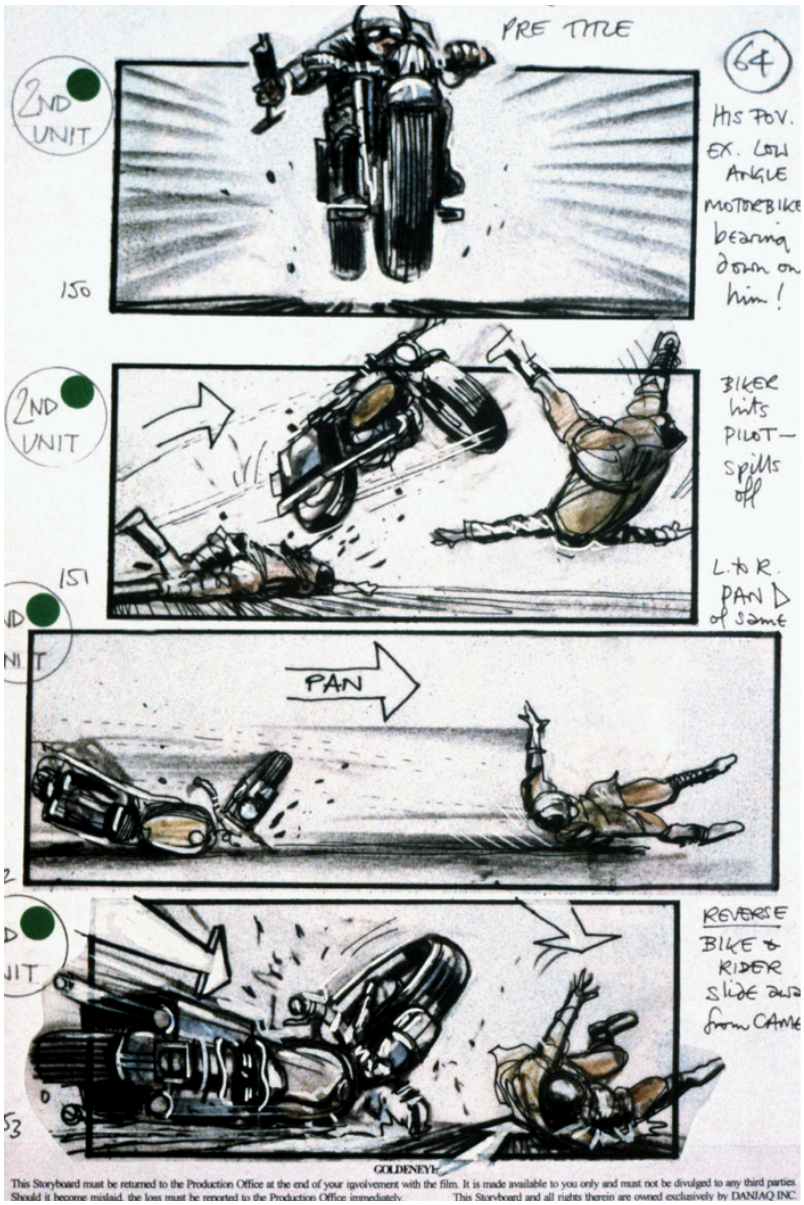
Previsualization

Ensuring that each shot's composition serves the movie's narrative, tone, and overall style requires a great deal of planning, so filmmakers use **previsualization** to aid them in visualizing each individual shot and to help them achieve a unified approach to shot compositions. Previsualization can include drawings of planned compositions called storyboards, diagrams of sets that include actor and camera positions called **overheads**, and software that creates three-dimensional models of sets and scenarios.



Director Martin Campbell worked with storyboard artists to plan compositions and camera moves for the James Bond film *Goldeneye* (1995)

Rule of Thirds

As a rule, our minds—and by extension our eyes—seek equilibrium and order. On the movie screen, that order often takes the form of a balanced composition. The **rule of thirds** breaks the frame into three vertical sections and three horizontal sections, resulting in a grid. This grid acts as a guide that filmmakers use to balance visual elements in the frame. It is not an exact science; art is never that simple. The basic idea is that composition is built in basic units of three: top, middle, bottom; left, center, right; foreground, middle ground, and background. Usually, for every visual element placed on one section, there will be a corresponding element in the opposite section to counterbalance the composition.

The Rule of Thirds in *Hidden Figures*

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Although the shots from an opening scene in *Hidden Figures* (2016) are composed differently, they each use the rule of thirds. In the closer angle, the balanced composition emphasizes the vertical. The overzealous trooper and the defiant Mary are positioned in the grid's left and right sections, with her companions Dorothy and Katherine centered in the background. Each woman occupies a different vertical third in the wider shot; Mary must share hers with the looming officer. The horizontal thirds in the wider shot are divided into highway, car, and sky. Notice how all three of our protagonists' faces fall near the top horizontal line in both compositions. Significant information is often placed in this area of the frame.

***Hidden Figures* (Theodore Melfi, 2016)**

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Elements of Composition

Composing the Frame

Our gaze is drawn to the area along the top horizontal line of a composition. For this reason, significant information, including the faces of characters, is often placed in this area. Because we humans tend to focus our attention on one another's eyes, close-up compositions often position characters' eyes along this upper line. This alignment has an added benefit. By framing a character's eyes at the level of the upper line, cinematographers can quickly and efficiently

establish a practical and aesthetically pleasing amount of space, or **headroom**, above the subject.

At the beginning of this Module, we saw an example of the compositional symmetry Wes Anderson used to lend *The French Dispatch* a sort of theatrical whimsy.

Composing the Frame: Symmetry

Stanley Kubrick used **symmetry** to different effect in *The Shining*. When one of Danny's Big Wheel rides through the Overlook Hotel brings him face-to-face with the ghosts of murdered twin girls, the scene's sudden uncanny symmetry radiates creepy menace.

***The Shining* (Stanley Kubrick, 1980)**

By purposely breaking the rule of thirds and denying our expectation of balance, filmmakers can create compositional stress. This intentional imbalance can communicate many levels of meaning, as always depending on the context in which it is used. A character can be made to appear diminished or disturbed, or a moment can be imbued with a sense of tension or foreboding.

Compositional Stress

The social marginalization of a guilt-ridden boy is expressed with unbalanced compositions in Lynne Ramsay's *Ratcatcher* (1999).

***Ratcatcher* (Lynne Ramsay, 1999)**

Sometimes what might appear to be imbalance is actually maintaining a different sort of balance. When a character is looking across the screen, she is typically placed on one end of the frame so that her gaze is balanced with what is called **eye room** (or looking room) on the opposite side of the composition. In our innate visual vocabulary, just the act of looking carries the weight necessary to stabilize a composition. Similarly, a character whose lateral screen movement is tracked by a moving camera is almost invariably given **lead room** on the side of the frame toward which she is moving.

Composing the Frame: Looking and Lead Room

These two different moments in *The Farewell* (2019; director Lulu Wang) illustrate the heft a character's gaze or forward momentum can bring to a composition. In the film's first scene, lead room balances the frame as Billi walks down a New York sidewalk while talking on the phone with her beloved grandmother in China.

***The Farewell* (Lulu Wang, 2019)**

Later, after she learns her grandmother has terminal cancer, Billi thinks of her as she stares across the subway platform at another old woman. In this scene, Billi's implied eye room takes up the rest of the composition.

The Farewell (Lulu Wang, 2019)

Another application of apparent imbalance is something called **negative space**. We are so accustomed to compositional balance that sometimes when we're presented with a lopsided composition, an expectation is created that something will arrive to restore balance. This technique is often used to generate suspense in narrative contexts featuring someone (or something) whose imminent arrival we anticipate—or fear.

Composing the Frame: Negative Space

In a suspenseful scene in *The Lord of the Rings: The Return of the King* (2003), the protagonist Frodo is tricked into becoming lost in a cave. He soon stumbles across a lair filled with massive webs and a sizable collection of silk-wrapped skeletons. When the narrative pauses at this composition, negative space creates the unsettling expectation that the inevitable giant spider will creep from the shadows to fill the empty space.

***The Lord of the Rings: The Return of the King* (Peter Jackson, 2003)**

Deep Space Composition

The composition conventions we've just described are primarily concerned with only two dimensions: height and width. After all, a movie screen is two-dimensional. But the world movies depict features a third dimension: *depth*. Since the early days of film, filmmakers have innovated ways to provide audiences the illusion of depth. In the 1930s, as new lenses and lights made it possible to capture depth when photographing images, cinematographers such as Gregg Toland (and his directing collaborators John Ford, Orson Welles, and William Wyler) began regularly using depth as a component of composition.

Deep-space composition emphasizes depth by placing significant visual and narrative information on two or more of the three planes of depth—foreground, middle ground, and background—in such a way that not only emphasizes depth but also conveys information, mood, and meaning. This meaning can take many forms, depending on how the levels of depth are presented. Meaning about the situation and relationships presented can be communicated by the relative placement of characters and objects, their relative size in frame, and whether or not a character is in focus.

Composing the Frame: Deep Space

In this deep-space composition from Orson Welles's *Citizen Kane* (1941), cinematographer Gregg Toland exploits all three planes of depth along a line that draws our eye from screen right to screen left. In the foreground telephone booth, the backlit reporter Mr. Thompson calls in his story; in the middle ground, the nightclub headwaiter patiently stands by; and, in a pool of light in the background, the drunk and distraught Susan Alexander Kane, the subject of Thompson's visit, mourns her ex-husband and her misspent life. Each character is photographed in clear focus in a unified setting, yet each occupies a separate physical, psychological, and emotional space.

***Citizen Kane* (Orson Welles, 1941)**

Alicia, the protagonist of Alfred Hitchcock's *Notorious* (1946), is being slowly poisoned to death by her husband and his Nazi collaborators. In this shot, deep-space composition uses relative size in frame to graphically compare Alicia's vulnerability and weakened condition to the significant threat posed by the poisoned coffee.

***Notorious* (Alfred Hitchcock, 1946)**

The way a camera frames the shots in a film can convey meaning in ways that are related to but go beyond mise-en-scène and composition.

Focus on Deep Space Composition

A scene from *The Little Foxes* (1941) demonstrates that every plane of action need not be in focus to achieve expressive deep-space composition. The invalid Horace has a heart attack shortly after denying his wife Regina the money she wants for a morally dubious investment. He begs her to retrieve his vital medication from an upstairs room, but the vindictive Regina remains motionless. As Horace struggles to reach the stairs in the background, he moves farther and farther out of focus. His increasing fuzziness communicates his rapidly fading grip on life, as well as his wife's efforts to disregard his impending death.

***The Little Foxes* (William Wyler, 1941)**